

THE THREE MINOR SCALES

Natural, harmonic, and melodic minor — each solving a different musical problem, each with its own emotional character.

THREE FLAVORS OF MINOR

NATURAL MINOR

NATURAL MINOR

DARK · MELLOW · AEOLIAN

1 2 $\flat 3$ 4 5 $\flat 6$ $\flat 7$

W-H-W-W-H-W-W

A B C D E F G

A natural minor uses the same 7 notes as C major — just starting on A. Called the **relative minor** of C major.

The most common minor. Used in pop, rock, folk. No alteration from the key signature needed. The $\flat 7$ means the leading tone is a whole step below root — V chord is minor, less urgency.

HARMONIC MINOR

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EXOTIC · TENSE · CLASSICAL

1 2 $\flat 3$ 4 5 $\flat 6$ 7

W-H-W-W-H-Aug2-H

A B C D E F G $\sharp$

The raised 7th creates an **Augmented 2nd** between $\flat 6$ and 7 — the characteristic exotic sound. The V chord becomes MAJOR (E7), giving a leading tone for V $\rightarrow$ i.

Built to solve a harmonic problem: natural minor's V is minor (Em), which lacks the pull toward home. Raising the 7th makes V major (E) or dominant 7th (E7), creating proper V $\rightarrow$ i resolution.

MELODIC MINOR

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SMOOTH · JAZZ · SINGABLE

1 2 $\flat 3$ 4 5 6 7

W-H-W-W-W-W-H

A B C D E F $\sharp$ G $\sharp$

Both the 6th *and* 7th are raised, eliminating the awkward Augmented 2nd of harmonic minor. Makes ascending lines smoother for voices and instruments.

Jazz theory keeps this same scale ascending AND descending (unlike classical which descends as natural minor). Only differs from major in the $\flat 3$ — that's what keeps it minor in character.

PARALLEL VS. RELATIVE

Two ways to relate a major and minor scale — understanding both prevents confusion when analyzing music.

PARALLEL (SAME ROOT, DIFFERENT NOTES)

C major $\leftrightarrow$ C minor

Both start on C but use different notes. C major = bright; C minor = dark version of the same home. The $\flat 3$, $\flat 6$, $\flat 7$ lower the character. Parallel comparison = same key center, different modes.

RELATIVE (SAME NOTES, DIFFERENT ROOT)

C major $\leftrightarrow$ A minor

Both use C-D-E-F-G-A-B but start in different places. A is the 6th degree of C major. Every major key has a relative minor starting on its 6th degree. Relative comparison = same key signature, different tonal center.